



AP PHOTO JOHN AMIS

asks his favourite painter to bring Qara Koz, his lost great aunt, to life, the artist falls in love with his subject—and turns himself into an imaginary being, literally. If Mohini the Skeleton, the sleepless whore of the Hatyapul brothel, the House of Skanda, can create life-saving fragrances, her erstwhile employer, the secret lover of Prince Salim, makes the male drugs that can turn men into horses. And in his dream, the Emperor visits Skeleton and her antithesis Mattress, Tansen, the musical genius of the era, has created raag deepak in the whores' honour. The royal court that Rushdie imagines is one of erotic excesses and cerebral playfulness, inhabited by sorcerers and storytellers.

It is not far away from the Florence of three friends—Antonio Argalia, the would-be soldier of fortune, Niccolo il Machia (Machiavelli), the priapic womaniser and thinker, and Ago Vespucci, a storyteller “in spite of the bleakness of his clerical future”. Their life begins from a magic wood, and in the end, they will be united by the enchantress. Their Florence, more specifically il Machia's Florence, is like Akbar's court. As Rushdie says, the incredible hedonism of the Mughal court is matched by the sensuous extremism of the renaissance world: “It was a great discovery to me. I thought I was writing about two worlds which were completely unlike each other. The more I read, the more I learned about the similarities. Both worlds are obsessed with magic. And there are all kinds of echoes in terms of power politics.” He creates a narrative pattern in which the echoes are juxtaposed. And Rushdie seems to have im-



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Jodha, his “imaginary wife”, “dreamed up by Akbar in the way that lonely children dream up imaginary friends.” (Says Rushdie, “It is absolutely clear to me from historical reading that the character of Jodhabai didn't exist.” He thinks the image got fixed in popular mind after *Mughal-e-Azam* and the role played by Prithviraj Kapoor. And Rushdie didn't have any idea that the movie *Jodhaa Akbar* was going to come out. “I didn't know it was being made.”) There is Bhakti Ram Jain, “Imperial Flatterer First Class”. There is Abul Fazl, “the man who knew everything”, and the brightest of the Nine Stars. There is Raja Birbal of “the lightning wit”. In the Tent of the New Worship, where the mystic Water Drinkers and the philosophical Wine Lovers face each other, argument is the only god. “But reason was a mortal divinity, a god that died... Ideas were like the tides of the sea or the phases of the moon, they came into being, rose and grew in their proper time, and then ebbed, darkened, and vanished when the great wheel turned.” When Akbar, “whose life-giving powers had been temporarily exhausted by the immense effort of creating and then sustaining his imaginary wife Jodha,”

mensely enjoyed giving himself to a fairyland of magic and sorcery, of witchcraft and enchantments. “I did enjoy it. Magic in that age was something they believed in. They used magic in their daily life.” To establish the link between the two worlds, Rushdie tells you, “You have to know everything in between.” Like the beginning of the Ottoman empire. And when he found out the truth about Dracula, “I couldn't believe my luck. There was no historical evidence to show that Dracula was involved in vampires. And he didn't come to Transylvania. It was all made up by Bram Stoker.” He was, as portrayed in the novel, extraordinarily bloodthirsty.

*The Enchantress of Florence* is an exuberant celebration of storytelling, and the story that Rushdie tells with such classical cadence brings out the sameness of distant cultures. The space between East and West shrinks. “I hesitate to say this. I haven't felt the kind of liberation, the kind of joy in the making of it, since I wrote *Midnight's Children*”, says Rushdie. It is a story that liberates the Emperor, enchants the reader and enriches the art of the novel.